

cost saving measure, and Linux bundled with netbooks are very popular, as this significantly reduces the price of the devices. Ubuntu is the most common distribution nowadays, because of its user friendliness and the ample support available on its forums.

Linux has found its way to cell-phones, desktops and office computers. The governments of many third world nations like Brazil, Spain, China, Peru, Pakistan and India are actively involved in promoting Linux and associated open source software. The French parliament works off Linux, and the entire city of Vienna has decided to take the plunge. Using Linux really puts you in better company, if not for ideological and political reasons, there are technological reasons as well. Linux is the most used operating system on supercomputers around the world, and the behemoth of modern technology, the LHC itself is controlled by Linux.

### Choosing a distribution

A Linux flavor or distribution (commonly referred to as a distro) is a specific set of software, windows management system, and a desktop environment packaged along with the Linux kernel. There are a wide range of distros available, for a wide range of specific and generic purposes.

For example, a non-commercial, highly-portable distro for a desktop would be Puppy Linux. A very comprehensive, non-commercial desktop distro would be Debian, and a commercial, very secure, enterprise distro would be SUSE. There are many permutations and combinations, as well as fundamentally different philosophies. Some distros are available only in their home language, for example, the Malayalam distro, Rachana, and the E-Swecha Telegu distro which is in development. There is a small, portable, multimedia centric distro called GeexBox, and Gentoo, a distribution that compiles the source code based on the hardware it is installed on, making it highly optimised for performance.

Distros of Linux have been around almost as long as Linux itself, and many distros have spawned child, grandchild and even great-grandchild distros. One of the big differences affecting end users are how installation files for software are distributed for these distros, and there are two families, rpm-based and deb-based. Debian and its derivatives used the deb installation, which includes Ubuntu. Most other Linux distros use the rpm packaging.

A distro typically has a mechanism for resolving dependencies, which are like .dll files for Windows. This can range from *yum* in